

Discussion on the Bondage of the Will

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Introduction

This paper will examine *The Bondage of the Will* by Martin Luther, and examine its arguments' strengths and weaknesses. In particular, it will look at synergism vs monergism, whether humans have a free will that can aid in salvation. My conclusion is that monergism is the more precise theological answer, but that synergism has some merit because humans are not robots.

Can I accept Christ and believe in Christ? As in, can *I* do it?

Posing this question still doesn't separate the two perspectives in the debate.

A more precise way to put it is: can I, on my own strength or free will, decide to accept Christ?

Another way to put it is, when God says to us, "Believe or die!" Is he commanding us to actually believe or is he simply pronouncing judgment on those he doesn't give faith to? As in does God give faith rather than us generating the faith?

And so lies the debate between Erasmus and Luther, where Erasmus says we have a certain amount of free will to choose to believe in God.

From my experiences with salvation in other people, I believe that one needs to be pressed into a corner and forced to accept Christ in order to receive that salvation. It is not a casual acceptance or choice - it is one where the human has no choice but to believe because it has no other option or escape for its flesh.

And this is the perspective Luther has, where our flesh is totally depraved, and we must receive that faith from God in order to believe in him.

But according to Erasmus, Erasmus also believes in grace alone for salvation. Also, Erasmus' perspective is not totally wrong because we must eventually choose Christ and believe in him - we are not stones or robots.

And so I am going to examine two sources that examine Luther's arguments.

First Source

The first is by Peckham,¹ where he says that *Bondage* makes Luther's soteriology explicit.

It turns out that Martin Luther's soteriology stems from his own experience of finding salvation. He says, "by his own understanding or strength he could not believe in Jesus Christ or come to him." " 'I did not love, yes, I hated the righteous God who punishes sinners . . . ' Thus Luther became certain that he could not be saved."

What this means is that Luther at first did not believe that he could approach a righteous God because he was unrighteous. This emphasizes his belief in total depravity and the lack of free will to choose God.

But the debate is more subtle than that. Luther says, that "free will delineates a will that is able to do just about anything." While, Erasmus says, "By free choice in this place we mean a power of the human will by which a man can apply himself to the things which lead to eternal salvation, or turn away from them."

What's happening is that Luther is saying that free will is the ability to do anything, not just receive salvation; while Erasmus says that free will is only in regards to salvation.

And I think it's an important point because Luther felt trapped in all aspects of his life by sin. He was obsessed with sin.

And Erasmus was simply pointing out that we are not robots, and we need to accept and believe in Jesus.

I think both are fair arguments.

Second Source

The second source examines the debate between Erasmus and Luther, and actually sides with

¹ John C. Peckham, "An Investigation of Luther's View of the Bondage of the Will with Implications for Soteriology and Theodicy," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society* 18, no. 2 (2007): 274–304.

Erasmus in some sense. It says, “Luther is then left with the dilemma of justifying the Responsibility Principle without free will – a task, which in our estimation, fails.”

What it’s saying is that Luther is trying to say that sinners are responsible for their sin even when they have no ability not to sin. If they are forced to sin, how can they be responsible for it?

And to this, I will say that I disagree because even though I cannot accomplish something, I can still be judged for not accomplishing it.

It is a question of whether I am judged because I choose to not do it even though I can, or whether I do it at all. These are two aspects of responsibility that need to be distinguished.

The first is like a judgment in character and is somewhat subjective, and the second is a judgment in behavior and is objective.

I believe that both are reasonable definitions for responsibility, and that depending on which definition you choose, you will get either Luther’s or Erasmus’ point of view.

Works Cited Format

- Peckham, John C. "An Investigation of Luther's View of the Bondage of the Will with Implications for Soteriology and Theodicy." *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society* 18, no. 2 (2007): 274–304.
- Visala, Aku, and Olli-Pekka Vainio. "Erasmus versus Luther: A Contemporary Analysis of the Debate on Free Will." *Neue Zeitschrift für Systematische Theologie und Religionsphilosophie* 62, no. 3 (2020): 311–35. <https://doi.org/10.1515/nzsth-2020-0016>